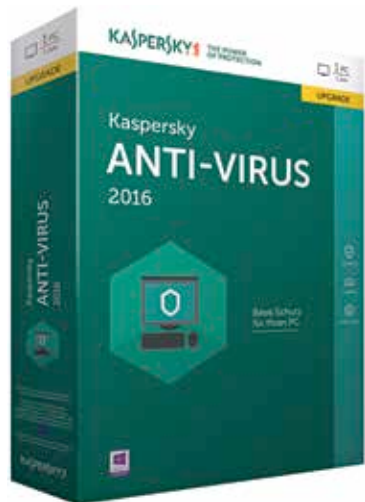


You might feel that protecting yourself against cyber attacks is a job only for specialists, but that isn't really the case. Also, securing yourself isn't about throwing money at the problem either. Sure you can choose to shell out a few bucks initially for the sake of convenience you don't really need to.

Of anti-virus software and firewalls

The most basic step anyone could take is to install an anti-virus software. For a long period of time, the understanding was that only careless Windows users, who had no inkling about separating the fishy links from the legitimate ones, and who roamed the weird and unsafe corners of the internet, needed to have an anti-virus program. But in today's age of zero-day vulnerabilities and large-scale hacking, this notion is a dangerous one to spread.

A zero day vulnerability refers to a hole in software that is unknown to the vendor and has the potential to be exploited by hackers in the form of infiltrating malware, spyware or illicit access to the software user's personal details and information. Such security loopholes are exploited by hackers before the vendor is made aware of them, and has led to many zero-day attacks in the past. For example, in March 2013, Oracle discovered two zero-day vulnerabilities, of which one was actively used by hackers in targeted attacks. The vulnerability could be exploited remotely, without any form of authentication to kick-start it in affected machines. Since the risk applied to both Windows and Mac devices, the number of possibly affected devices could run into millions. There's also the massive Elderwood project, a platform that has used, as researched and reported by Symantec, an "unlimited number of zero-day exploits, attacks on supply chain manufacturers who service the target organization, and shift to 'watering hole' attacks" on websites likely visited by the target organization". Their biggest target was Google, back in 2012. Though no data was stolen or



An example of an anti-virus software